

AI and water

Posted by u/sketchypuzzle • 0 points • 1 comments

Does anybody know good research reports, books, or videos on the effects of AI on water?

Comments

u/devanclara • 1 points • 2026-03-02 05:50 UTC

<https://www.lincolnst.edu/publications/land-lines-magazine/articles/land-water-impacts-data-centers/>

u/Happy_Rogue_663 • 5 points • 2026-02-27 08:54 UTC

TLDR; a lot compared to an average household, but their water usage is a rounding error compared to how much water we use to grow alfalfa (cow food)

Check out this Lawrence Berkeley National Lab study on data centers, especially Fig 5.9 for water usage: <https://escholarship.org/uc/item/32d6m0d1>

Across the entire US in 2024, they used ~20 million gallons/yr. Seems like a lot.

Morrow County Oregon (has 5x more cows than people) uses 300 million gallons per year, all for agriculture. This is a “middle of the road” county for water agriculture withdraws in the western US, but they have a higher than average # of cattle. Every single data center in the country used only ~7% of Morrow County’s water withdraws for growing alfalfa (and some onions, potatoes, mint).

Put another way, every single data center in the entire US in 2024 used LESS water than a standard 120-acre center-pivot alfalfa field in the arid west would use in a growing season.

If you’ve ever driven through Arizona, New Mexico, Utah, Idaho, eastern Oregon/Washington, any individual green circle uses wayyy more water than data centers do. (They also pollute the heck out of our water bc of excess nitrogen from fertilizer and cow poop, but that’s another issue)